

Orryn "Fid" Cogspinner

Male Rock Gnome Artificer, 402 years old

The Age of Whimsy

Even among the Cogspinner gnomes, a clan whose name was synonymous with intricate clockwork artistry, young Orryn was a revelation. His laughter was as constant as the ticking of a thousand clocks, and his mind saw the world not in shapes and colors, but in interlocking gears and powered springs. While other gnomes built marvelous toys, Fid built companions. His most famous early creation was "Glimmer," a hummingbird automaton with wings of spun glass and a heart of polished sunstone. It didn't just fly; it danced on the air, chirping melodies that could soothe a crying baby or inspire a poet. He gave his creations away freely, finding his deepest joy not in the making, but in the smile an invention brought to someone's face. His workshop was a place of mirth, smelling of fresh pine, sweet oil, and bubbling laughter.

The Shadow in the Fields

This idyllic life shattered in Fid's 74th year. The nearby Ambrosian Fields, a wild and ancient forest, vomited forth a tide of horror. They were the Domvoys, fey creatures of twisted wood and shadow, who could mimic the shapes of animals or even the people they had just slain. They descended upon the local villages not for conquest, but for the sheer, malicious joy of sowing terror. Fid witnessed a Domvoy, wearing the face of a beloved neighbor, lead a child into the woods, only to hear the child's scream abruptly cut short. The mirth of the region was replaced by the silence of fear.

Word was sent to the Empire, and after a season of terror, help arrived. They were the Grave Wardens, an Imperial division of grim, hardened soldiers, their penitent silence a stark contrast to the gnomes' panicked chatter. The war was brutal. For two years, the clang of the Wardens' steel and the unnatural shrieks of the Domvoy echoed through the hills. The cost was high, but the Grave Wardens were relentless. They cleansed the Ambrosian Fields, leaving pyres of smoking, twisted fey wood in their wake.

A Pact of Gratitude and Iron

The Cogspinner clan, and Fid most of all, were overwhelmed with gratitude. He approached the Grave Warden commander and asked how he could possibly repay the Empire. The commander,

having heard tales of the gnome prodigy, saw an opportunity. The Empire had enemies far greater than the Domvoy.

The Empire commissioned Fid to build tools of war.

The request felt like a dissonant chord in the symphony of Fid's soul. He, a creator of joy, was being asked to create instruments of pain. But the memory of the Domvoys, of the child's scream, was still raw. He reasoned that to protect the innocent, sometimes one must build a sharper sword. It was his duty.

He packed away his schematics for songbirds and dancing automatons and delved into the grim mathematics of destruction. His first creation for the Empire was the "Scuttler," a beetle-like automaton that could skitter across a battlefield on six metal legs before detonating in a shower of shrapnel. He watched its first test, a wave of pride at its perfect execution warring with a wave of nausea at its purpose. His workshop began to smell of sulfur and ozone.

The Arcane Upgrade and the Gilded Cage

For decades, Fid served as the Empire's master weapon smith. Each shipment of Scuttlers or soaring "Shrike-bombs" he sent to the capital was more ingenious than the last. Yet, every report that came back spoke of a new, more terrible enemy: the sorcerous hordes of the Eternal Legions.

A chance meeting with an Imperial battlemage opened a new door. The wizard spoke of magic not as some unknowable force, but as a system of cosmic laws that could be understood, manipulated, and woven into the physical world. For the next fifty years, Fid's obsession shifted. He devoured arcane texts, his brilliant mind mapping the flow of magical energy as if it were another complex gear train. He learned to infuse his clockwork with magic, creating weapons that were not just deadly, but supernaturally so. He was no longer just a tinkerer; he was an Artificer.

His creations turned the tide in key battles, and his importance grew immeasurably. The Emperor decreed that such an asset could no longer remain in the provinces. For his own protection, Fid was to be relocated to the capital. Though it broke his heart to leave his clan, he saw the logic. It was his duty.

In the capital, his resources were limitless, but his spirit was imprisoned. His workshop was a sterile, stone laboratory deep within the Imperial palace, a far cry from his sun-drenched home. The laughter was gone, replaced by the grim-faced guards at his door. He was a celebrated hero,

yet a prisoner in a gilded cage. He missed the smell of the forest, the warmth of his community, and above all, the simple, honest joy he once knew. A deep depression took root.

The Road to Ruin

His magnum opus was born from this despair: **Project Peacekeeper**, a colossal war wagon moving on a dozen thrumming, metallic legs. It was a mobile fortress, an autonomous engine of destruction capable of leveling everything in a half-mile radius. It was deployed to the front lines against the Eternal Legions near the dreaded **Black Fortress** and proved devastatingly effective.

Then, word came that the Peacekeeper had suffered a critical mechanical failure. Rather than risk months transporting it, the Empire decided to transport its creator to the front. The journey was a shock to Fid's sequestered soul. The first week, traveling through the Imperial heartland, he saw peaceful villages and happy children kept safe by his work. A sliver of his old pride returned.

The second week was a descent into hell. As they neared the war front, the landscape became a canvas of atrocities. He saw burned-out farmsteads, fields salted with the dead, and hollow-eyed orphans whose faces would haunt him forever. He saw the true cost of the war he had been fueling from his comfortable, isolated lab.

The Cog That Slipped

The final straw came when his armed convoy crested a hill overlooking a small, obliterated hamlet. A dozen dwellings scorched and collapsed. Bloated bodies rotting in the sun. A profound and chilling familiarity washed over Fid as he surveyed the damage. The pattern of destruction, the sheer obliterating force that had turned stone to dust and people to ash... it was unique. It was the signature of his own creation. This was the work of the Peacekeeper.

Among the rubble, something caught his eye. It was a small, metal bird, its glass wings shattered, half-buried in the mud. It was a Glimmer. One of his own, a toy of joy he had given to a village child on a festival day long ago, now lying broken in a grave of his own making.

In that instant, Orryn Cogspinner's mind, that brilliant clockwork of logic and reason, shattered. A gear tooth snapped, a spring flew loose, and the whole intricate machine of his sanity fell

apart. The horror was too immense to process, so his mind simply... broke. A high, airy chuckle escaped his lips, disconnected from the tears streaming down his face.

His keepers, seeing his state, managed to focus him long enough to complete the repairs on the Peacekeeper, his hands moving with the muscle memory of a master, even as his mind reeled in a kaleidoscopic nightmare. They then returned the "Hero of the Empire" to his lab in the capital.

The Laughing Ghost in the Machine

Fid still builds weapons. His brilliance is undimmed; his creations are more potent than ever. But the man is a ghost. He talks to his tools, bursts into peals of nonsensical laughter at random moments, and carries on conversations with the memory of the hummingbird on his shoulder. To an outsider, he almost seems happy, a quirky old gnome lost in his work. But this is the sound of a mind trying to piece itself back together with broken parts.